The fertilized egg undergoes development and it is implanted in the uterus. The corpus luteum continues to grow and produces large amount of progesterone. This results in pregnancy. Normally, it lasts for 280 days, at the end of which parturition takes place.

Menstruation

If the ovum is not fertilized, the corpus luteum begins to degenerate and the production of hormones progesterone and estrogen ceases. The unfertilized egg and the thickened lining of the uterus along with its blood vessels are shed off. This causes bleeding in woman's reproductive tract which is called menstruation. Menstruation occurs once in about 28 to 30 days. It takes about 3 to 5 days. In some cases, initially menstrual cycle may be irregular. It takes some time to become regular. If it remains irregular for over a year, then it is better to consult a doctor.

Menopause

Menopause marks the end of the reproductive phase of a woman's life. At 45 to 50 years of age, the menstrual cycle stops. Stoppage of menstruation is termed as 'menopause'. During menopause psychological symptoms such as anxiety, irritability, fatigue and loss of concentration may occur. Menopause may be induced by surgical removal of the ovaries, or by pelvic irradiation in a woman of any age.



Now-a-days girls attain puberty at very early age. This is due to food habits. As you eat a lot of junk food, the body growth increases and it looks like adults.

20.5 Menstrual Cycle

The beginning of the menstrual cycle marks the onset of puberty in human females. The menstrual cycle begins with the casting off of endometrial lining of the uterus and bleeding. The casting of endometrium can be considered as periodic preparation for pregnancy. Menstruation occurs if an ovum released by the ovary of a woman is not fertilized during ovulation. This is described below.

1. When a girl reaches puberty at the age of about 10, the sex hormones released into her blood cause some of the ova (or egg cells) in her ovaries to become mature (or ripe).
2. Usually one mature ovum (or egg) is released from one of the ovaries into the oviduct once in every 28 days. This is called ovulation.
3. Before ovulation (or release of ovum), the inner wall of uterus becomes thick and spongy, and full of tiny blood vessels (or blood capillaries). It prepares itself to receive the fertilized ovum.
4. If the ovum does not get fertilized then the thick and soft inner lining of uterus is no longer needed and hence it breaks. So, the thick and soft inner lining of uterus along with the blood vessels and the dead ovum comes out of the vagina in the form of a bleeding called menstruation.

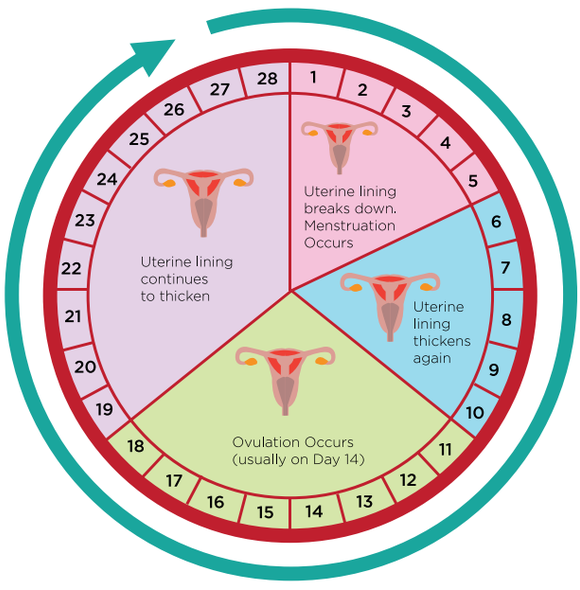


Figure 20.4 Menstrual Cycle

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